regional allies such as Iran, Russia, and the Central Asian Republics, however, offered strategic sufficiency.[3] It had nothing to do with India's fondness for the Tajik, Uzbek or Hazara communities over the Pashtuns. New Delhi, as put by popular Indian media in 1996, had 'no option but to help Rabbani' at that point in time, for which there were strong moral and legal grounds.[4] Shaped in the context of the Taliban's stupendous rise and South Asian geopolitics, India's siding with the UF is often seen as a natural progression of New Delhi's Afghanistan policy in the 1990s, especially in light of strained relations with Pakistan.[5] In accordance with the UN's position, there was allegedly little disagreement in India over providing political, diplomatic and moral support to Rabbani and Massoud. The military component of this relationship, however, was covert. Officially, India was actively advocating non-interference by external players in Afghanistan, but unofficially, it was providing military and financial support to the UF.[6] This was similar to Pakistan's support to the Taliban, but small in comparison. Such popular discourse on India's links with the UF miss the many contradictions of this policy approach.

India's links with the UF, despite their endurance, were highly complex and delicate. For one, India's decision not to engage with the Taliban did not automatically imply siding with the UF. The question, after all, was not just about giving diplomatic recognition to the Rabbani government, but about the nature and extent of the support that India provided. Mostly symbolic, India's material support to the UF was insufficient in helping turn the military tide against the Taliban. As the twentieth century came to a close, and the Taliban's control increased across Afghanistan, India's covert war chest was used more for counter-bribing UF fighters whom the ISI was simultaneously cultivating.[7] The blunt balance of power logic guided this activity, which contributed to alienating the Taliban and other Pashtun communities from India. Also, having practiced non-interference in Afghan affairs from at least 1992 (as Rao had promised, and somewhat delivered on) why did New Delhi change its approach in 1996? The Taliban after all, wanted to engage with India, just like the Mujahideen. Moreover, throughout the 1990s India had no capital investments (despite India's desire of having some) or human personnel to protect in Afghanistan.[8] New Delhi's relationship with Kabul was simply that of a minor aid donor with its